



CHIDAMBARAM WITH AROON PURIE (RIGHT)

illiterate, and the most vulnerable. They are holding the tribal areas not because they are helping the tribals. They are holding them largely because they have put the fear of force in the tribals. They are going to expand what are called liberated zones, and only yesterday, one of their leaders declared that they were going to expand their armed liberation struggle activities to urban areas, set up urban cells, unleash urban guerrilla warfare, and to create chaos in India's cities.

Responding to concerns expressed by human rights activists, we have said that the Government would talk provided the Maoists abjure violence. Why are they unable to make the simple statement: we abjure violence. They will

never abjure violence and their document says that: We will never lay down arms; we will never abjure violence because it's part of our policy that we can seize power only through an armed liberation struggle. Faced with that, what does the state do? What should the state do? The state therefore says: it is the legitimate right of the state to use that much of force that is necessary to reclaim control over territories where the civil writ does not run. That is precisely the way we have formulated our policy. States have followed in line. We now have an enthusiastic response from Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh and more recently from West Bengal and Jharkhand and Orissa. There is one or two other states which seem ambivalent but I'm sure they will quickly accept this policy and join the operations against the Maoists.

I am confident that if we remain steadfast in this path of carefully controlled, calibrated operations to reclaim territories that are dominated with the Maoists, we should be able to rid ourselves of the menace in about two-three years, and then bring about development. As we reclaim control over these areas, we should be able to push development. These are the twin challenges the country faces today—one is jihadi terrorism, the other is Maoism. In recent months, there is a greater degree of consensus on the approach to facing these twin threats and overcoming them. I am confident that before the term of UPA II is over, we would have substantially got rid of the menace of Naxalism and we would have strengthened our security system to face up to any threat of terror from any corner of the world.

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DISCUSSION

Q. There is very little of Pakistan in your speech. Should we not be taking a tougher stand with Pakistan?

A. Pakistan is our neighbour and we can't change our neighbour. We can only make an attempt to change our neighbour's behaviour towards us. We have a serious problem with Pakistan revolving around Kashmir. Pakistan now allows state and non-state actors to support terrorism in India. It is no secret that every militant organisation that is based in Pakistan is supported by ISI, the Lashkar, the Hizbul Mujahideen, the Jamaat-ud-Dawa and Al-Badr. Every one of them has been supported by the ISI and every one of them was earlier based

in Pakistan. Now if it is official policy to ignore the distinction between the state and non-state players, to sponsor terrorism, to export terrorism to India, how do we deal with that state? It is a difficult neighbour. It must reinvent itself and one way to do that is becoming a truly democratic country where the real power lies in the hands of democratically elected leaders.

Q. What would be our response if there is another 26/11?

A. If we are able to establish with a reasonable degree of certainty that another attack on India emanated from Pakistani soil, we will respond swiftly and decisively.

Q. I'm Sami Mohammad SM Al-Sulaiman, ambassador of

Kuwait in New Delhi. I am not comfortable about combining the terms jihadi and terrorism. I would rather prefer that we call it international terrorism.

A. I have no difficulty in agreeing with you. But what other phrase should I use? Al Qaeda leaders use the word jihad. LeT leaders use the word. We have voice transcripts of the Mumbai attackers and their handlers using the word. I would be very happy not to use the word jihad. But the terrorists and their supporters also should stop using the word jihad. They must not bring a bad name to the great religion of Islam.

Q. I'm the high commissioner of Pakistan in New Delhi. I assure you no state actors are involved

in any acts against India.

A. I do not want to enter into a public debate with the high commissioner of Pakistan, but let us put a simple test. We have voice transcripts of the conversations between the handlers and attackers of 26/11. We want to know whose voice is that, who that handler was. Why can't we test our commitment to anti-terrorism by sharing voice samples of those who are suspected to be the handlers? These samples can be compared to the voice in the transcripts in a laboratory of a neutral country. Let's find out if the voice in the transcripts matches with any of the voice samples. We will know if the person was a state or a non-state actor.